

## hypethesis

## Blue Laser Discs

## ■ What are they?

These are optical disks invented by Philips where up to 1 GB of information can be stored on a disk measuring just 3 cm in diameter—nearly twice the amount that can be stored on conventional 8 cm CDs that hold 700 MB of data. The disk also has special drives being developed for it, to be used in portable devices like digital cameras, MP3 players, handheld devices and even cell phones.

## ■ How does it work?

The disks are fabricated using blue lasers instead of the conventional red lasers. Having smaller wavelengths, the lasers can read data packed in a denser format. Correspondingly, the pit size and track spacing is also lower than conventional CDs and even DVDs. The prototype drive to read these disks measures just 2.2x1.3x0.3 inches. Standard sized CDs using this technology feature capacities of up to 27 GB.

## ■ What does it mean to me?

Optical disks are far cheaper than other forms of digital storage and given their size, they are ideally suited to mobile applications in place of technology like Flash memory, which is costlier. These types of storage media are also far more robust as compared to other solid-state memory implementations.

## Copying media for personal use legal?

In reponse to Hollywood's aggressive anti-piracy issues, a bill has been presented in Washington to protect the rights of consumers to make



ILLUSTRATIONS: Mahesh Benkar

copies of digital music, movies and books. Called the Digital Choice and Freedom Act, the bill will "help retard the growth of efforts to roll over

consumers' rights," said representative Zoe Lofgren. The state Assembly Committee on Arts, Entertainment, Sports, Tourism and Internet Media will host an all-day hearing investigating the impact of Internet music piracy on California's recording industry. The bills could balance the political debate that so far has favoured the entertainment industry.

The bill would amend federal copyright laws to extend consumers' fair use rights to copyright-protected entertainment that comes in digital form.

## What's in a name?

The Free Software Foundation (FSF), headed by open source evangelist Richard Stallman, has called for Linus Torvald's operating system to be renamed GNU/Linux.

Linux has rapidly become a well-known operating system, and Stallman argues that GNU's role in its development is not getting enough recognition. His document states his point saying, "This system is basically a version of the GNU system, modified to use the Linux kernel. We started developing

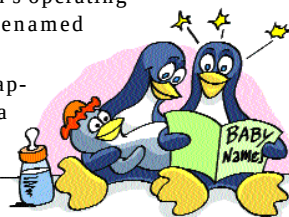
the system in 1984, years before Linus Torvalds got involved, and we also wrote the largest part of the

code. In fairness, we

ought to get equal mention."

The FSF's demands have split the open source community. Some

have suggested that the organisation is just being petty, while others back its argument but think that the FSF is fighting an uphill battle, as all GNU/Linux-based systems will simply be shortened to 'Linux'.



## Google launches news service

Google has beefed up its Web site using its search engine technology to add ground-breaking news services. Google News scans 4000 news sources in real time, creating a dynamic page displaying top news.

The front page offers brief headlines and a synopsis of the stories with photographs. When you click on a headline, you are taken to the source's Web site to read the full story. If you choose a related link, a list of stories on the same subject from competing news outlets is displayed, allowing you to take your pick. "People can now pick a story and then decide the source, instead of picking a source and finding a story," says Marissa Mayer, Google.com product manager.

The service is completely automated and relies on the same information-ranking technology used in the Google search engine to deliver relevant results.

## snapshot

Digital video recorders to reach **1.8 million** by end of **2003** and **19.1 million** by 2006

Source: The Yankee Group

■ HP to bundle CD, DVD Writers on Pavilion desktops and notebooks ■ Intel launches 11 mobile CPUs up to 2.2 GHz and ups Celeron to 2 GHz